PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #1 · TRUSTING OTHERS · MISTRUST

# "I can't let my guard down."

✦ ✦ ✦

Are you having problems trusting others? Do you feel anxious and suspicious about their motives? Do you fear letting your guard down? The information below is intended to help you take a step toward trusting others and find the peace that comes from knowledge of God's word as found in the Bible.

## Where it often comes from

Feeling betrayed, bullied, deceived, or mistreated can result in a person being more or less constantly alert and anxious. You may find you spend a great deal of your time scanning your environment, looking out for possible threats. Unpredictable relationships, traumatic events, repeated criticism, or messages that nobody can be trusted may strengthen these expectations. The message you may be hearing is: "Don't let down, or something dreadful might happen." Or, you might hear yourself thinking: "People just can't be trusted."

## How the belief can keep itself going

Expecting harm can lead to scanning for threats, withdrawing, testing people, or responding defensively. Those responses may reduce opportunities to learn that some relationships are dependable. The task is to compare expectations with present evidence while preserving appropriate boundaries.

## What Scripture teaches

God invites us to put our trust in Him when we are afraid, rather than letting fear determine every relationship. Scripture also describes the goodness of companionship, receiving help, carrying one another's burdens, and loving each other. These passages challenge the expectation that closeness can bring only harm. With God's help, I can make room for people who show care and reliability, accept support, and discover that I do not have to face life alone.

> *"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight"* (Proverbs 3:5–6).

## Also see

> "When I am afraid, I put my trust in You. In God, whose word I praise— in God I trust. I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?" (Psalm 56:3–4).

> "Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor. For if one falls down, his companion can lift him up; but pity the one who falls without another to help him up!" (Ecclesiastes 4:9–10).

> "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ" (Galatians 6:2).

> "This is My commandment, that you love one another as I have loved you" (John 15:12).

## Common self-statements

- People always have a hidden agenda.
- If someone is kind, they probably want something.
- I must watch for every sign of betrayal.
- If I relax, I will miss the danger.
- I cannot tell anyone what I really think.
- Depending on someone gives them power to hurt me.

## Common logical errors

- Overgeneralization: Applying one person's betrayal to all people.
- Mind reading: Treating a guess about someone's motives as a known fact.
- Selective attention: Noticing signs of danger while overlooking consistent, respectful behavior.
- Emotional reasoning: Taking the feeling of being unsafe as proof of a present threat.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Assuming my only choices are complete trust or complete distrust.
- Catastrophizing: Predicting serious harm from an ordinary interaction without enough evidence.

## Challenging questions

- What happened that I can directly observe, and what meaning have I added?
- What evidence supports my concern? What evidence points another way?
- Am I responding to this person's behavior or to an earlier betrayal?
- What are two other possible explanations?
- Has this person respected a clear boundary before?
- What small amount of trust, if any, fits the evidence?
- Can I protect myself without assuming that everyone intends harm?

## Truth summary

> I can trust God with my fears and allow caring people to become part of my life. Past betrayal does not determine what every new relationship will be. Some people are dependable, and I can learn to recognize and receive their care. I can take small steps toward connection, ask for help, and let trust grow through shared experience.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Trust
- Friendship
- Love, For Others
- Help
- Fear

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Communication
- Thinking, Healthy

## Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

Trust in You — lyric video




Trust in You — Lauren Daigle

An invitation to trust God even when circumstances feel uncertain.

'Tis So Sweet to Trust in Jesus — lyric video




'Tis So Sweet to Trust in Jesus — Alan Jackson

Encourages resting in Christ's promises and learning to trust Him.

He Will Hold Me Fast — lyric video




He Will Hold Me Fast — Keith & Kristyn Getty

Reassurance of Christ's faithful care when fear makes trust difficult.

I Am Not Alone — lyric video




I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe

Reassures me of God's faithful presence, helping me face fear without feeling that I must handle everything alone.

## Clinical background

For counselors: beliefs like this are often discussed in connection with what clinicians call paranoid personality disorder. This original educational example uses cognitive restructuring, checking interpretations, and modest behavioral experiments. It is informed by the cognitive model of personality beliefs; it is not a DSM criterion, a quotation from Beck, or a validated treatment protocol.

Beck Institute: Beliefs in personality disorders · Beck, Davis, & Freeman (Eds.), Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders (3rd ed.)

*Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"*

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "I can't let my guard down"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

"I can't let my guard down." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ What facts do I know, and what am I assuming?
- ☐ What evidence does not fit my fear?
- ☐ What else could explain this person's behavior?
- ☐ Is an old experience shaping my expectation?
- ☐ What boundary would help me make a measured choice?
- ☐ What small step fits this person's actual track record?

My own question: _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ When I am afraid, I can put my trust in God.
- ☐ I do not have to face every difficulty alone.
- ☐ Some people will respond to me with kindness and care.
- ☐ I can receive help without assuming there is a hidden motive.
- ☐ Past betrayal does not mean every relationship will end in betrayal.
- ☐ I can allow trust to grow through small experiences of dependable care.

In my own words: _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- ☐ **Proverbs 3:5–6**
  *"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight."*
- ☐ **Psalm 56:3–4**
  *"When I am afraid, I put my trust in You. In God, whose word I praise— in God I trust. I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?"*
- ☐ **Ecclesiastes 4:9–10**
  *"Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor. For if one falls down, his companion can lift him up; but pity the one who falls without another to help him up!"*

- [ ] Galatians 6:2
  *"Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ."*
- [ ] John 15:12
  *"This is My commandment, that you love one another as I have loved you."*

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

# Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Trust and support log: Each day, record one time someone showed kindness, kept a promise, listened, or offered help. Describe what I allowed myself to receive and what I learned.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, a personalized adaptation of Psalm 56:3 (based on BSB) is: "When Sarah is afraid, she puts her trust in You."*
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Trust" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

Choose a modest, ordinary situation. These exercises do not require revealing private information or approaching anyone who has threatened, coerced, or abused you. A respectful response is useful evidence; a boundary violation is useful evidence too.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

- [ ] Accept one small offer of help. Choose a person who has shown reliability. Accept ordinary help, such as help with a task, and notice what actually happens.
- [ ] Ask someone to listen. Tell a caring friend about a modest everyday concern and ask for a few minutes of listening. Compare their actual response with what I predicted.
- [ ] Make room for companionship. Invite a dependable friend to a short walk, coffee, or another comfortable shared activity. Notice moments of warmth or connection.
- [ ] Acknowledge dependable care. Thank someone for a specific way they have supported me. Write down how it feels to recognize and receive that care.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Review what you learned; bring this page to counseling if you are attending.*

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie “I can't let my guard down”: _____ %  My truth: _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | Care or support I received |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

| Day | Song I listened to | What it told me that challenges the lie |
|---|---|---|
| Mon | | |
| Tue | | |
| Wed | | |
| Thu | | |
| Fri | | |
| Sat | | |
| Sun | | |

## My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can't let my guard down.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Father, when I am afraid, help me put my trust in You. Heal the hurts that have taught me to expect betrayal. Help me recognize people who show kindness and faithfulness, receive their support, and take small steps toward friendship. Teach me to give and receive love, and remind me that I do not have to carry every burden alone. In Jesus' name, Amen.*

*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*

PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #2 · TRUSTING OTHERS · SUSPICION OF MOTIVES

# "Friendliness usually hides an ulterior motive."

✦ ✦ ✦

Are you having problems accepting help from friends or significant others in your life? Do you tend to mistrust their motives or positive intentions? The information below is intended to help you take a step toward trusting the helpful words or actions given by friends, spouses, or others. The objective is to accept the fact that at least some friendly advice can be a positive influence in your life, and is consistent with God's word as revealed in the Bible.

## Where it often comes from

Past manipulation, broken promises, betrayal, or inconsistent care may teach a person to question friendly behavior. These experiences can make caution understandable. But the mind may start treating a possible motive as a proven motive—even when someone is simply being kind.

## How the belief can keep itself going

When friendliness is seen as a trap, a person may pull away, question compliments, or test others. A guarded response can make interactions tense, leaving fewer chances to discover genuine care. A better approach is to observe behavior over time and use reasonable boundaries.

## What Scripture teaches

Scripture encourages wisdom and careful listening, but also love, hope, and attention to what is true. Trusting God does not require blind trust in every person. It allows us to examine evidence without assuming that all kindness is dishonest.

> *"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight." (Proverbs 3:5–6)*

## Also see

> "It bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things." (1 Corinthians 13:7)

> "Finally, brothers, whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable—if anything is excellent or praiseworthy—think on these things." (Philippians 4:8)

> "My beloved brothers, understand this: Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger," (James 1:19)

> "He who answers a matter before he hears it—this is folly and disgrace to him." (Proverbs 18:13)

## Common self-statements

- They're being nice because they want something.
- No one is friendly without a reason.
- A compliment is probably a trap.
- If I accept help, I'll owe them.
- I need to figure out what they really want.

- People only pretend to care.

## Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming you know a person's hidden intentions.
- Jumping to conclusions: Deciding friendliness is manipulation without enough evidence.
- Overgeneralization: Treating some past dishonest people as proof about everyone.
- Confirmation bias: Remembering suspicious moments and discounting genuine kindness.
- Emotional reasoning: Mistaking a feeling of distrust for proof of danger.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Assuming kindness must be completely sincere or completely fake.

## Challenging questions

- What did this person actually say or do?
- What evidence suggests an ulterior motive? What evidence does not?
- Could ordinary kindness explain the same behavior?
- Am I judging this person by someone else's past actions?
- Has this person respected a boundary or accepted a 'no'?
- What would a balanced, cautious interpretation sound like?
- What small response would let me learn more without risking too much?

## Truth summary

Some people may have selfish motives, but many acts of friendliness are genuine. I can respond with courtesy, observe patterns, and maintain appropriate boundaries. I do not need to assume the worst before I have evidence. I can ask God for wisdom and choose a measured response.

## Related Pearls topics

Open these topics in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Trust
- Protection
- Friendship
- Love, For Others
- Fear

Godly Counsel Lessons — read or print:

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Communication
- Thinking, Healthy

## Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes
>
> Your browser cannot play this audio.

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

Click a picture to play inside this card. A YouTube link is provided as a fallback.

The Same Love
Paul Baloche

Reflect on love that welcomes and restores, rather than assuming every caring gesture conceals a selfish motive.

Goodness of God
CeCe Winans

Rehearse examples of faithful goodness instead of attending only to possible betrayal.

No Longer Slaves
Jonathan David & Melissa Helser

Let assurance of belonging to God loosen the fear that turns ordinary kindness into a perceived threat.

Trust in God
Elevation Worship feat. Chris Brown

Practice resting in God's faithfulness while remaining open to receiving sincere care from others.

*Official lyric videos with words on screen. Songs play inside the card; YouTube may show ads.*

## Clinical background

For counselors: beliefs like this are often discussed in connection with what clinicians call paranoid personality disorder. This educational example uses CBT methods: checking evidence, generating alternative interpretations, and trying low-risk behavioral experiments. Suspiciousness may be associated with paranoid personality patterns, but a single belief is not a diagnostic test. Avoid experiments with people who have threatened, exploited, or abused you.

Beck Institute: Personality Belief Questionnaire materials · Beck, Davis, & Freeman, Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders

*Each morning ask: "What evidence do I have about this person's motives, and how can I respond wisely today?"*

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "Friendliness usually hides an ulterior motive."

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Check one choice in each section or write your own. Choose a question and a truth that feel meaningful to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it from 0% to 100%.*

> "Friendliness usually hides an ulterior motive." I believe this _____ %.

## 2 My best question

*Select a question to ask when suspicion appears.*

- ☐ What did this person actually say or do?
- ☐ What evidence suggests an ulterior motive? What evidence does not?
- ☐ Could ordinary kindness explain the same behavior?
- ☐ Am I judging this person by someone else's past actions?
- ☐ Has this person respected a boundary or accepted a 'no'?
- ☐ What would a balanced, cautious interpretation sound like?

My own question:

## 3 My replacement truth

*Select a balanced statement to practice.*

- ☐ Kindness may be genuine; I can look at the evidence.
- ☐ I do not have to know someone's motives immediately.
- ☐ I can be friendly while keeping sensible boundaries.
- ☐ A compliment does not automatically create an obligation.
- ☐ I can wait for patterns of behavior before deciding.
- ☐ God calls me to wisdom, not constant suspicion.

In my own words:

## 4 My Scripture

*Choose one passage to remember; these are the same passages shown on the card.*

- ☐ Proverbs 3:5–6
  *"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight."*
- ☐ 1 Corinthians 13:7
  *"It bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things."*
- ☐ Philippians 4:8
  *"Finally, brothers, whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable—if anything is excellent or praiseworthy—think on these things."*

- [ ] James 1:19
  *“My beloved brothers, understand this: Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger,”*
- [ ] Proverbs 18:13
  *“He who answers a matter before he hears it—this is folly and disgrace to him.”*

The verse I will practice:

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# Practicing the Truth

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## 5 Rehearse the truth daily

*Read your chosen Scripture, listen, and practice a balanced thought.*

Read Pearls: Trust. Listen to Overcoming Anxiety. Say your replacement truth aloud once in the morning and once in the evening.

Today I noticed this change:

## 6 Try a small behavioral experiment

*Choose a safe, low-risk test; do not ignore real warning signs.*

- ☐ When a familiar person offers a small courtesy, say thank you without trying to guess their motive. Later, note what actually happened.
- ☐ Accept a minor, no-strings-attached kindness from someone with a history of respecting your boundaries. Record whether a demand followed.
- ☐ Offer a small kindness to another person with no expectation of repayment. Reflect on how kindness can be genuine.
- ☐ For one week, record both examples of sincere kindness and examples of self-interest. Compare the whole pattern.
- ☐ When someone compliments you, write down three possible explanations—including a sincere one—before deciding.
- ☐ Set a polite boundary ('No, thank you') and notice whether the person respects it. Do not test someone who has been unsafe.

My prediction:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

## 7 Track what changes

*Practice for seven days. Mark what you tried and rate belief strength.*

| Day | What I practiced | Belief % | What I learned |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | | | |
| 2 | | | |
| 3 | | | |
| 4 | | | |

| Day | What I practiced | Belief % | What I learned |
|---|---|---|---|
| 5 | | | |
| 6 | | | |
| 7 | | | |

## Song reflection

After listening to one of the four songs, write a sentence about trusting God and treating people fairly.

Song:

A truth I want to remember:

## My Truth Card

OLD BELIEF:
~~Friendliness usually hides an ulterior motive.~~

NEW TRUTH:
I can recognize genuine kindness through evidence and time, while keeping healthy boundaries.

MY SCRIPTURE:
Proverbs 3:5–6

## A short prayer

*Lord, help me notice what is true instead of assuming what others intend. Give me wisdom to recognize danger, courage to receive sincere kindness, and love that does not rush to judge. Amen.*

*Scripture quotations: Berean Standard Bible (BSB), public domain. Educational material only; not a diagnosis or substitute for professional care.*

PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #3 · TRUSTING OTHERS · HIDING THE REAL ME

# "I need to hide the real me in order to not get hurt."

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Deep down, do you fear that others, if they got to know you, would hurt, ridicule, or make fun of you? Because of this, do you hide your real feelings or the real you? The information below is intended to help you lessen your fear of others by trusting in God's love and care for you as expressed in the Bible. You don't need to hide from God and, with God's help, you can start to be more open and trusting with other people.

## Where it often comes from

If honesty was met with ridicule, rejection, punishment, or betrayal, hiding may once have felt protective. A person may learn to show only a polished version of themselves. Over time, a response to particular experiences can become a rule: being known always leads to being hurt.

## How the belief can keep itself going

Hiding feelings, agreeing when we disagree, and pretending to be fine can reduce anxiety briefly. But others have fewer opportunities to understand or support us. Feeling unseen can then seem to prove that closeness is impossible. Small, chosen moments of honesty can help us learn whether a trustworthy person responds with care.

## What Scripture teaches

God knows us deeply and invites us to approach Him with confidence. His acceptance gives us a foundation for living more honestly. Scripture also calls believers to welcome one another and share burdens. These passages invite connection; they do not promise that every person will respond well or require us to share everything with everyone.

> *"O LORD, You have searched me and known me. You know when I sit and when I rise; You understand my thoughts from afar." (Psalm 139:1–2)*

## Also see

> "Trust in Him at all times, O people; pour out your hearts before Him. God is our refuge. Selah" (Psalm 62:8)

> "Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need." (Hebrews 4:16)

> "Accept one another, then, just as Christ accepted you, in order to bring glory to God." (Romans 15:7)

> "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ." (Galatians 6:2)

## Common self-statements

- If people really knew me, they would use it against me.
- I must look strong and keep my struggles hidden.
- My honest feelings will drive people away.
- It is safer to be what others expect.
- I should say I am fine even when I need support.
- Being known means losing control.

## Common logical errors

- Overgeneralization: Turning past rejection into a rule about all relationships.
- Fortune telling: Treating a feared hurt as certain before it happens.
- Mind reading: Assuming people would reject the real me without checking.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must either hide everything or reveal everything.
- Emotional reasoning: Taking the feeling of vulnerability as proof that I am unsafe.
- Discounting the positive: Dismissing experiences of being accepted when I was honest.

## Challenging questions

- What part of myself am I afraid to show, and what do I predict will happen?
- Am I assuming this person will react like someone who hurt me before?
- Who has already responded with kindness when I was honest?
- Does keeping everything hidden protect me, or also leave me lonely?
- Can I share one small, ordinary truth instead of everything at once?
- Could someone disagree with me and still care about me?
- How might God's knowledge and acceptance of me change this rule?

## Truth summary

I do not have to hide all of myself to be worthy of love or to build meaningful relationships. God knows me and welcomes me. I can allow people who have shown care and respect to know me gradually. Honesty cannot guarantee that I will never be hurt, but hiding everything also has a cost. I can be authentic and still choose healthy boundaries.

## A short prayer

*Lord, thank You for knowing me and inviting me close. Help me release the need to appear perfect. Give me courage to be honest, wisdom about whom to trust, and openness to receiving love. Amen.*

## Related Pearls topics

Open these topics in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Trust
- Friendship
- Love, For Others
- Fear

Godly Counsel Lessons — read or print:

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Communication
- Thinking, Healthy

## Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes
>
> Your browser cannot play this audio.

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

Click a picture to play inside this card. Each selection is an official lyric video with words on screen.

Known
Tauren Wells

Reflect on being fully known and loved by God rather than needing to keep your real self hidden.

Truth Be Told
Matthew West & Carly Pearce

Challenge the pressure to pretend that everything is fine and consider one honest request for support.

Come As You Are
Crowder

Practice approaching God with your hurts and needs rather than waiting until you look perfect.

Who You Say I Am
Hillsong Worship

Let belonging to God support an identity that does not depend on maintaining a protective image.

*YouTube may show ads.*

## Clinical background

For counselors: beliefs like this are often discussed in connection with what clinicians call paranoid personality disorder. This card follows Identify → Challenge → Replace, using evidence review, balanced alternatives, daily rehearsal, and small behavioral experiments. Hiding the self can occur with suspiciousness, shame, social anxiety, or past relational injury; it is not specific to a personality disorder. This is an individualized educational formulation, not a DSM criterion or a diagnostic test. Psychological difficulties have multiple contributing factors. Sharing personal information is a choice; experiments should involve ordinary, low-stakes honesty with someone who has shown respect.

Beck Institute: Personality Belief Questionnaire materials · Beck, Davis, & Freeman, Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders

*Each morning ask: "What small part of the real me can I express honestly today?"*

# My Plan for Replacing "I need to hide the real me in order to not get hurt."

✦ ✦ ✦

Check one choice in each section or write your own. Choose a question and a truth that feel meaningful to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it from 0% to 100%.*

> "I need to hide the real me in order to not get hurt." I believe this _____ %.

## 2 My best question

*Select a question to ask when you feel you must hide.*

- ☐ What part of myself am I afraid to show, and what do I predict will happen?
- ☐ Am I assuming this person will react like someone who hurt me before?
- ☐ Who has already responded with kindness when I was honest?
- ☐ Does keeping everything hidden protect me, or also leave me lonely?
- ☐ Can I share one small, ordinary truth instead of everything at once?
- ☐ Could someone disagree with me and still care about me?

My own question:

## 3 My replacement truth

*Select a balanced statement to practice.*

- ☐ I can be known and still be loved.
- ☐ My feelings and needs do not make me unworthy of care.
- ☐ I can choose what to share, with whom, and when.
- ☐ Some people can respond to honesty with kindness and respect.
- ☐ I can let trust grow through small experiences of being real.
- ☐ God knows me deeply; I do not need a perfect image to approach Him.

In my own words:

## 4 My Scripture

*Choose one passage to remember; these are the same passages shown on the card.*

- ☐ Psalm 139:1–2
  *"O LORD, You have searched me and known me. You know when I sit and when I rise; You understand my thoughts from afar."*
- ☐ Psalm 62:8
  *"Trust in Him at all times, O people; pour out your hearts before Him. God is our refuge. Selah"*
- ☐ Hebrews 4:16
  *"Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need."*
- ☐ Romans 15:7

*"Accept one another, then, just as Christ accepted you, in order to bring glory to God."*

☐ Galatians 6:2
*"Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ."*

The verse I will practice:

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# Practicing the Truth

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## 5 Rehearse the truth daily

*Read your chosen Scripture, listen, and practice a balanced thought.*

Read Pearls: Trust. Listen to Overcoming Anxiety. Say your replacement truth aloud once in the morning and once in the evening.

Today I noticed this change:

## 6 Try a small behavioral experiment

*Choose a safe, low-risk test; do not ignore real warning signs.*

- ☐ With a person who has respected you, express a small preference instead of automatically agreeing. Predict their response, then record what they actually do.
- ☐ When a trusted friend asks how you are, share one ordinary feeling, such as being tired or a little worried. Notice whether they listen with care.
- ☐ Ask a reliable person for a small favor. Compare what you predicted with the response you received.
- ☐ Admit a minor, everyday mistake to a kind person. Notice whether being imperfect prevents connection.
- ☐ Tell a trusted person about a harmless interest or opinion you usually keep hidden. Look for evidence of curiosity, acceptance, or respectful disagreement.
- ☐ Write an honest prayer about a feeling you hide. Then consider one small part you might choose to share with a trustworthy person.

My prediction:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

## 7 Track what changes

*Practice for seven days. Mark what you tried and rate belief strength.*

| Day | What I practiced | Belief % | What I learned |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | | | |
| 2 | | | |
| 3 | | | |
| 4 | | | |
| 5 | | | |

| Day | What I practiced | Belief % | What I learned |
|---|---|---|---|
| 6 | | | |
| 7 | | | |

## Song reflection

After listening to one of the four songs, write a sentence about being known, accepted, and honest.

Song:

A truth I want to remember:

## My Truth Card

OLD BELIEF:
~~I need to hide the real me in order to not get hurt.~~

NEW TRUTH:
I can be known and loved. I can show the real me gradually to people who have earned my trust.

MY SCRIPTURE:
Psalm 139:1–2

## A short prayer

*Lord, thank You for knowing and loving me. Help me practice honest connection today, receive kindness, and remember that I do not have to appear perfect to be worthy of care. Amen.*

*Scripture quotations: Berean Standard Bible (BSB), public domain. Educational material only; not a diagnosis or substitute for professional care.*

PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #4 · TRUSTING OTHERS · HIDDEN INTENTIONS

# "People always try to hide what they are doing"

✦ ✦ ✦

Do you often suspect that people are hiding their real intentions or planning something they will not tell you about? Does this leave you constantly on guard, looking for clues for their true intentions? The information below can help you separate what you know from what you fear, ask clear questions, and find peace in God's care while allowing trust to grow through honest relationships.

## Where it often comes from

Believing that you have been deceived, betrayed, or surprised by someone's harmful actions can teach you to expect that they are communicating hidden plans or meanings. Family secrecy, unpredictable behavior, or repeated warnings about other people can strengthen the belief that you must always search beneath the surface to find people's true meanings or intentions. Even ordinary privacy or an incomplete explanation may then feel like evidence of deception--even without a solid basis for this belief.

## How the belief can keep itself going

Expecting concealed intentions can lead to checking, repeatedly questioning people, or replaying conversations for clues. Checking may briefly ease anxiety, but it can make uncertainty feel harder to tolerate. Another person's discomfort with repeated questioning may then seem to confirm the original suspicion. Pausing, asking one respectful question, and comparing predictions with observable behavior can interrupt this cycle.

## What Scripture teaches

God invites us to bring our worries to Him and receive His peace. We are not required to uncover every private thought or predict every action. Love makes room for patience and hope, and faithful friendship can grow through experience. Trusting God helps us respond to what is actually happening instead of treating every unanswered question as proof of deception.

> *"When I am afraid, I put my trust in You." (Psalm 56:3)*

## Also see

> "You will keep in perfect peace the steadfast of mind, because he trusts in You." (Isaiah 26:3)

> "Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you." (1 Peter 5:7)

> "A friend loves at all times, and a brother is born for adversity." (Proverbs 17:17)

> "It bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things." (1 Corinthians 13:7)

## Common self-statements

- They are keeping something from me.
- If I stop watching, they will catch me off guard.
- There must be another reason they are doing this.
- I need to work out what they are really planning.
- A vague answer means they are deceiving me.
- I cannot relax until I know their true intentions.

## Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming I know an intention that has not been stated.
- Overgeneralization: Turning past deception into an expectation about everyone.
- Jumping to conclusions: Treating incomplete information as proof of a hidden plan.
- Confirmation bias: Looking for clues that support suspicion while dismissing openness.
- Catastrophizing: Predicting harm whenever I do not know someone's plans.
- Emotional reasoning: Treating anxiety as evidence that deception is occurring.

## Challenging questions

- What did I directly observe, and what intention am I guessing?
- Does missing information necessarily mean deliberate deception?
- Could privacy, distraction, uncertainty, or a change of plans explain this?
- What consistent actions support a more trusting interpretation?
- Can I ask one clear question without accusing or repeatedly checking?
- What would I do differently if I could tolerate not knowing everything?

## Truth summary

I cannot know every thought or plan another person has. Uncertainty and ordinary privacy do not prove deception. I can ask clear questions, notice consistent actions, and allow reliable people to earn my trust. I can place my anxiety in God's care without constantly searching for hidden intentions.

## A short prayer

*Father, help me separate what I see from what I fear. Calm the urge to search for hidden motives. Give me patience to listen, courage to ask kindly, and peace to leave unanswered questions with You. Help me recognize and receive honest care. Amen.*

## Related Pearls topics

Open these topics in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Trust
- Friendship
- Wisdom
- Truth

Godly Counsel Lessons — read or print:

- Communication
- Judgmental
- Thinking, Healthy

## Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes
>
> Your browser cannot play this audio.

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

Click a picture to play inside this card. Each selection is an official lyric video with words on screen.

Whom Shall I Fear (God of Angel Armies)
Chris Tomlin

Practice placing fear in God's care instead of feeling responsible for anticipating every threat.

Peace Be Still
Hope Darst

Reflect on receiving peace when uncertainty makes you anxious.

Just Be Held
Casting Crowns

Consider releasing the pressure to keep everything under your control.

Be Still
Hillsong Worship

Pause the search for hidden intentions and focus on God's faithful presence.

*YouTube may show ads.*

## Clinical background

For counselors: beliefs like this are often discussed in connection with what clinicians call paranoid personality disorder. This card follows Identify → Challenge → Replace, using evidence review, balanced alternatives, daily rehearsal, and small behavioral experiments. Generalized distrust can follow betrayal, trauma, or abuse and may occur with anxiety, depression, or other conditions; it is not specific to a personality disorder. This is an individualized educational formulation, not a DSM criterion or a diagnostic test. Psychological difficulties have multiple contributing factors. Distrust can be reasonable when someone is unsafe; experiments should be low-stakes, and anyone in an abusive or dangerous situation should seek safety and professional help.

Beck Institute: Personality Belief Questionnaire materials · Beck, Davis, & Freeman, Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders

> *Each morning ask: "Can I respond to today's facts with patience and trust, without trying to uncover every hidden thought?"*

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "People always try to hide what they are doing"

✦ ✦ ✦

Check one choice in each section or write your own. Choose a question and a truth that feel meaningful to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it from 0% to 100%.*

> "People always try to hide what they are doing" I believe this _____ %.

## 2 My best question

*Select a question to ask when you suspect someone is hiding a plan.*

- ☐ What did I directly observe, and what intention am I guessing?
- ☐ Does missing information necessarily mean deliberate deception?
- ☐ Could privacy, distraction, uncertainty, or a change of plans explain this?
- ☐ What consistent actions support a more trusting interpretation?
- ☐ Can I ask one clear question without accusing or repeatedly checking?
- ☐ What would I do differently if I could tolerate not knowing everything?

My own question:

## 3 My replacement truth

*Select a balanced statement to practice.*

- ☐ Not knowing everything does not prove that someone is deceiving me.
- ☐ A person can have privacy without intending harm.
- ☐ I can ask once, listen carefully, and return to my own activities.
- ☐ Consistent actions are better evidence than guesses about motives.
- ☐ I can tolerate some uncertainty and still make sensible choices.
- ☐ God cares for me; I do not need to monitor everyone's plans.

In my own words:

## 4 My Scripture

*Choose one passage to remember; these are the same passages shown on the card.*

- ☐ Psalm 56:3
  *"When I am afraid, I put my trust in You."*
- ☐ Isaiah 26:3
  *"You will keep in perfect peace the steadfast of mind, because he trusts in You."*
- ☐ 1 Peter 5:7
  *"Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you."*
- ☐ Proverbs 17:17
  *"A friend loves at all times, and a brother is born for adversity."*

☐ 1 Corinthians 13:7
*“It bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things.”*

The verse I will practice:

---

# Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

## 5 Rehearse the truth daily

*Read your chosen Scripture, listen, and practice a balanced thought.*

Read Pearls: Trust. Listen to Overcoming Anxiety. Read your Truth Card three times daily and memorize your chosen verse. Set a phone or watch reminder, or place a note where you will see it. Listen to one song daily and record the truth you want to practice.

Today I noticed this change:

## 6 Try a small behavioral experiment

*Choose a safe, low-risk test; do not ignore real warning signs.*

- ☐ In an ordinary interaction with a reliable person, write the observable facts separately from your guess about their intentions. List two other explanations.
- ☐ Ask one neutral question about a small uncertainty, such as “Could you explain the plan?” Listen without repeating the question for reassurance.
- ☐ When there is no concrete sign of danger, postpone an unnecessary check for 15 minutes. Rate your anxiety before and after, then return to an ordinary task.
- ☐ Agree on one small shared plan with a dependable friend. Compare what you predicted with what the person actually did.

Choose an ordinary, low-stakes situation. Do not use these exercises with someone who is threatening, coercive, or abusive, or to dismiss concrete evidence of deception.

My prediction:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

## 7 Track what changes

*Practice for seven days. Mark what you tried and rate belief strength.*

| Day | What I practiced | Belief % | What I learned |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | | | |
| 2 | | | |
| 3 | | | |
| 4 | | | |

| Day | What I practiced | Belief % | What I learned |
|---|---|---|---|
| 5 | | | |
| 6 | | | |
| 7 | | | |

## Song reflection

After listening to one of the four songs, record the song, the truth it reinforces, and one way to practice that truth today.

Song:

A truth I want to remember:

## My Truth Card

OLD BELIEF:
~~People always try to hide what they are doing~~

NEW TRUTH:
Missing information is not proof of deception. I can ask clearly, judge actions fairly, and trust God with what I do not know.

MY SCRIPTURE:
Psalm 56:3

## A short prayer

*Lord, thank You that You are faithful. Help me notice trustworthy people, trust wisely, set healthy limits, and remember that I am safe in Your care. Amen.*

*Scripture quotations: Berean Standard Bible (BSB), public domain. Educational material only; not a diagnosis or substitute for professional care.*

PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #5 · TRUSTING OTHERS · KEEPING THINGS IN PERSPECTIVE

# “Little things often have great significance”

✦ ✦ ✦

Does one small remark, mistake, delay, or change in someone’s expression take on great importance in your mind? Do you find yourself making a mountain out of a molehill? The information below can help you widen your attention, examine the evidence, and give everyday events a fair sense of proportion. God’s Word offers guidance for responding with patience, perspective, and peace.

## Where it often comes from

When small details once preceded criticism, conflict, or disappointment, you may have learned to watch them closely. Repeated warnings, perfectionistic expectations, or stressful experiences can also teach you that little mistakes have major consequences. A habit that once seemed protective may continue even when today’s small event has little lasting importance.

## How the belief can keep itself going

Selective attention draws you toward one troubling detail while the rest of the situation fades into the background. Magnification then makes that detail seem more serious, meaningful, or lasting than the evidence supports. For example, a friend’s brief reply may overshadow years of kindness and become “proof” that the friendship is failing. Replaying the detail can increase anxiety and lead to reactions that are larger than the original event warrants.

## What Scripture teaches

Scripture encourages us to consider what is true and to widen our attention beyond a single upsetting detail. Patience allows time to listen before we react. We can address today’s actual problem without adding imagined consequences for tomorrow. Bringing anxiety to God can help us choose a response that fits the facts. Some small details do matter; the goal is to evaluate their importance rather than automatically magnify them.

> *“Finally, brothers, whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable—if anything is excellent or praiseworthy—think on these things.” (Philippians 4:8)*

## Also see

> “My beloved brothers, understand this: Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger,” (James 1:19)

> “A man’s insight gives him patience, and his virtue is to overlook an offense.” (Proverbs 19:11)

> “Therefore do not worry about tomorrow, for tomorrow will worry about itself. Today has enough trouble of its own.” (Matthew 6:34)

> “Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you.” (1 Peter 5:7)

## Common self-statements

- That small comment must mean something serious.
- One mistake changes everything.

- If I ignore this detail, I will regret it.
- This little setback shows that everything is going wrong.
- I need to keep thinking about it until I know its full meaning.
- The fact that I noticed it means it must be important.

## Common logical errors

- Selective attention: Focusing on one troubling detail while missing neutral or positive information.
- Magnification: Exaggerating the importance, severity, or likely consequences of a small event.
- Catastrophizing: Extending a minor setback into a prediction of disaster.
- Overgeneralization: Using one moment to judge an entire relationship, ability, or future.
- Emotional reasoning: Assuming that because an event feels significant, it must be significant.

## Challenging questions

- What actually happened, described without adding a conclusion?
- Am I focusing on one detail and overlooking the rest of the picture?
- What evidence makes this important, and what evidence suggests it is minor?
- How important is this on a scale from 0 to 10 compared with a genuinely serious problem?
- Will this probably matter in a week, a month, or a year?
- What would a calm, fair observer say about this?
- What response fits the actual size of the problem?

## Truth summary

Little things can matter, but they do not always have great significance. A single detail is only part of the picture. I can check the facts, consider the context, and respond in proportion to the actual problem. I can trust God with my concerns and give my attention to what is true and constructive.

## A short prayer

*Father, help me see the whole picture when one small detail fills my mind. Teach me to distinguish a minor concern from a serious problem. Give me patience to pause, wisdom to respond in proportion, and peace as I place my worries in Your care. In Jesus' name, Amen.*

## Related Pearls topics

Open these topics in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Trust
- Friendship
- Wisdom
- Truth

Godly Counsel Lessons — read or print:

- Communication

- Judgmental
- Thinking, Healthy

## Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes
>
> Your browser cannot play this audio.

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

Click a picture to play inside this card. These lyric videos display words on screen.

Voice of Truth
Casting Crowns

Reflect on testing a frightening interpretation against truth rather than letting fear give one detail its meaning.

Battle Belongs
Phil Wickham

Bring worries to God and reflect on seeing beyond the difficulty that currently fills your attention.

Turn Your Eyes
Sovereign Grace Music

Shift attention toward Christ and place a troubling detail within a larger perspective.

Look Up Child
Lauren Daigle

Practice looking beyond an upsetting moment and remembering God's care.

*YouTube may show ads.*

## Clinical background

For counselors: this card targets selective attention (mental filtering) and magnification. It follows Identify → Challenge → Replace through reviewing context, scaling importance, generating balanced alternatives, and testing proportionate responses. These thinking habits occur across different difficulties and do not establish a personality disorder. The exercises are educational applications of CBT principles, not a validated treatment protocol for this exact sentence. Evaluate genuine warning signs in context; proportionate thinking does not mean dismissing actual harm.

Beck Institute: Personality Belief Questionnaire materials · Beck, Davis, & Freeman, Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders

*Each morning ask: "How can I keep small problems small, see the whole picture, and respond with God's wisdom today?"*

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "Little things often have great significance"

✦ ✦ ✦

Check one choice in each section or write your own. Choose a question and a truth that feel meaningful to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it from 0% to 100%.*

> "Little things often have great significance" I believe this _____ %.

## 2 My best question

*Choose a question that helps you put a small event in perspective.*

- ☐ What actually happened, described without adding a conclusion?
- ☐ Am I focusing on one detail and overlooking the rest of the picture?
- ☐ What evidence makes this important, and what evidence suggests it is minor?
- ☐ How important is this on a scale from 0 to 10 compared with a genuinely serious problem?
- ☐ Will this probably matter in a week, a month, or a year?
- ☐ What would a calm, fair observer say about this?
- ☐ What response fits the actual size of the problem?

My own question:

## 3 My replacement truth

*Select a balanced statement to practice.*

- ☐ One small event does not tell the whole story.
- ☐ My attention can make a detail feel bigger than it is.
- ☐ I can consider the whole situation before deciding what it means.
- ☐ An unpleasant moment is not necessarily a major problem.
- ☐ I can handle a small problem with a small, practical response.
- ☐ God can help me respond with patience and perspective.

In my own words:

## 4 My Scripture

*Choose one passage to remember; these are the same passages shown on the card.*

- ☐ Philippians 4:8
  *"Finally, brothers, whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable—if anything is excellent or praiseworthy—think on these things."*
- ☐ James 1:19
  *"My beloved brothers, understand this: Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger,"*
- ☐ Proverbs 19:11
  *"A man's insight gives him patience, and his virtue is to overlook an offense."*

- [ ] Matthew 6:34
  *"Therefore do not worry about tomorrow, for tomorrow will worry about itself. Today has enough trouble of its own."*
- [ ] 1 Peter 5:7
  *"Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you."*

The verse I will practice:

---

# Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

## 5 Rehearse the truth daily

*Read your chosen Scripture, listen, and practice a balanced thought.*

Read Pearls: Trust. Listen to Overcoming Anxiety. Read your Truth Card three times daily and memorize your chosen verse. Set a phone or watch reminder, or place a note where you will see it. Listen to one song daily and record the truth you want to practice.

Today I noticed this change:

## 6 Try a small behavioral experiment

*Choose a safe, low-risk test; do not ignore real warning signs.*

- ☐ Widen the picture: Record one minor upsetting event. Write the troubling detail, then add five relevant facts you initially overlooked. Rate its importance before and after.
- ☐ Use a fair scale: Place a small inconvenience on a 0–10 importance scale, with concrete examples of minor, moderate, and serious problems. Choose a response of similar size.
- ☐ Try a small response: For an ordinary, low-stakes issue, pause for ten minutes and use one brief practical action instead of prolonged analysis. Compare your prediction with the result.
- ☐ Check over time: Predict how much a minor event will matter tomorrow. Revisit it the next day and compare its actual consequences with your expectation.

Choose a minor everyday event, such as a brief reply, a small mistake, or a short delay. Do not postpone action on urgent safety, health, or financial concerns.

My prediction:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

## 7 Track what changes

*Practice for seven days. Mark what you tried and rate belief strength.*

| Day | What I practiced | Belief % | What I learned |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | | | |
| 2 | | | |
| 3 | | | |
| 4 | | | |

| Day | What I practiced | Belief % | What I learned |
|---|---|---|---|
| 5 | | | |
| 6 | | | |
| 7 | | | |

## Song reflection

After listening to one of the four songs, record the song, the truth it reinforces, and one way to practice that truth today.

Song:

A truth I want to remember:

## My Truth Card

OLD BELIEF:
~~Little things often have great significance~~

NEW TRUTH:
One detail is not the whole picture. I can check its importance and give a small problem a proportionate response.

MY SCRIPTURE:
Philippians 4:8

## A short prayer

*Father, help me see the whole picture when one small detail fills my mind. Teach me to distinguish a minor concern from a serious problem. Give me patience to pause, wisdom to respond in proportion, and peace as I place my worries in Your care. In Jesus' name, Amen.*

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